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Multilateral agencies in the construction of the global agenda on education

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This article traces the construction of the educational dimension of the global development agenda over the period 1990 to 2006. It argues that the multilateral agencies, and notably the World Bank, UNICEF, UNESCO and UNDP, played vital roles in designing the architecture of this world agenda, supported at a key stage by the Development Assistance Committee (DAC) of the OECD. The milestones in this process were the World Conference on Education for All in 1990, the OECD DAC Report on *Shaping the 21st Century* in 1996, the World Forum in Dakar in April 2000, and the Millennium Summit of September 2000. These processes identified a series of goals and targets, including in education, that were time-bound and circumscribed in their range and coverage. The enthronement of the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) following the Millennium Summit of 2000 as the centrepiece in the world's development agenda, is particularly worthy of careful analysis. It is suggested that the multilateral agencies played the dominant role in the construction both of the MDGs and of their predecessors, the International Development Targets (IDTs), and that, as a consequence, these may well not be strongly owned by developing countries in the way that is often claimed that they are.

Introduction

In 2006, it was more than 15 years since the World Conference on Education for All had taken place in Jomtien (Thailand), and it was 10 years since the Development Assistance Committee (DAC) of the Organization for Economic Development and Cooperation (OECD) had established the International Development Targets (IDTs). In 2000, the World Forum in Dakar reinforced the Jomtien vision on education for all; and following the Millennium Summit later that same year the International Development Targets were, with some revision, confirmed as the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs).

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This period of 15 years saw the reaffirmation of the notion of time-bound targeting in international education (see King & Rose, 2005), which had once been evident in the three great regional education conferences of UNESCO in Santiago (1962), Karachi (1960) and Addis Ababa (1961).[1] But it also saw the education priorities being embedded in a cluster of other global goals such as poverty reduction, HIV/AIDS, malaria, child mortality and environmental sustainability. There was no longer a question of there being just an educational target, therefore; education became part of the global development agenda. Mechanisms were also established in the Global Monitoring Reports (GMRs), the Millennium Project Report and its Task Forces, and Millennium Summit of 2005, to evaluate the world's progress towards these agreed goals.

Given the salience of these events, and their presumed impact on the educational priorities of national governments and of development agencies, it is perhaps surprising how little analysis there has been of exactly how this global education architecture was constructed. For the international development community, of course, the place names, Jomtien and Dakar, and the acronyms, IDTs, MDGs and GMRs, don't need to be explained as they have become part of the development lexicon. But the process whereby these became part of the accepted landscape of international education remains largely unstudied. In particular, the role of multilateral bodies in advancing this agenda has been little researched (but see Jones, 2005).

This article retraces some of the steps in the construction of this global agenda, and will pay special attention to the multilateral players involved. We shall need to acknowledge how little we know about the attitudes of the nations on whose behalf this world agenda was being developed. How has the erection of these priorities affected different kinds of countries, and most notably those who are most aid-dependent? Also, how far is the MDG process owned by such countries as China and India, which are much less aid-dependent?

It will become clear that the present argument is very provisional. One of its purposes is to point to the need for further research within some of the key institutions, as well as within the planning units of national ministries. In an age when it has become mandatory for donors to stress the importance of the country ownership of their own education agendas, it would indeed be paradoxical to discover that the allegedly global education agenda was perceived by many analysts in the south to have been principally developed by multilateral agencies in the north.

The Jomtien vision of education within the decade of World Conferences

There was an enormous amount of literature associated with Jomtien (Thailand), the site of the World Conference on Education for All (WCEFA, 5–9 March 1990), but very little of it discussed its origins. With the benefit of hindsight it can, of course, be seen as the first in a whole decade of World Conferences. This began with education at Jomtien in March 1990 and continued with children (New York, September 1990); environment (Rio de Janeiro, 1992); human rights (Vienna 1993); population (Cairo, 1994); social development (Copenhagen, 1995); women (Beijing, 1995);

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human settlements (Istanbul, 1996); food security (Rome, 1996); and climate change (Kyoto, 1997). The phenomenon of the World Conference is intriguing in its own right, and it may not be entirely coincidental that these began to occur very shortly after the world had ceased to be bipolar with the fall of the Berlin Wall.[2]

Many of these conferences were associated with a specialized lead agency, but this was not the case of the Conference in Jomtien. The four main sponsors of it were the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) and the World Bank. But it is interesting to note that the person who emerged as the Executive Secretary of this World Conference was Wadi Haddad, who had until just before this time been in charge of the World Bank's central education policy department. The reasons for each of the lead agencies being associated with this particular World Conference have been discussed by Jones (2005), and the history of how the particular text was changed from an initial UNICEF consultation in 15–17 February 1988[3] to the final draft that went to Jomtien, and was then revised in Jomtien by the International Steering Committee, has been recorded by King (1990) in *NORRAG NEWS* 7 and 8 (*NORRAG NEWS*, 1990a, b).

Apart from the negotiations for leadership among these four agencies, there was clearly debate about what was the primary focus of this World Conference. One thing was certain: it was explicitly more about 'basic education' than about 'primary education'; these last two words only appear together ten times in the 37 pages of the *World Declaration on Education for All* and its accompanying *Framework for Action to meet Basic Learning Needs*. By contrast, 'basic education' appears no less than 76 times! 'Basic learning needs' occurs 47 times, and 'education for all' 22 times. The message is clear: the Conference was much less about the conventional categories of primary, secondary, technical & vocational, and higher education than about the new would-be inclusive concept of basic education or the rather vague notion of 'basic learning needs'. Indeed, surprisingly, with the exception of primary education, none of these traditional categories is named at all in the entire document, with the exception of higher education which is mentioned just once (WCEFA, 1990).[4]

Basic education had been associated with UNESCO in the 1950s but at that time it had a strong link to community education, the use of mother tongue and adult literacy. Hence it was important to emphasize that the Jomtien version of basic education was an expanded one. The extent of what was originally included under basic education or under 'education for all' (EFA) is important to underline in view of the shrinkage that was to happen to this expanded vision almost immediately. At Jomtien it covered no less than early childhood education, primary schooling, adult literacy, essential skills for youth and adults, and access to knowledge and skills via the mass media. Each of these elements had particular professional constituencies that were anxious to ensure that their interests and priorities were represented as the drafts were elaborated and revised in the months prior to the World Conference and at the conference itself. The draft text had also been exposed to a series of 7 regional meetings across the world. These, too, sought to make the existing text reflect the realities of education within their regions. It was

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in fact extraordinary that a World Conference on Education should have managed to be conducted in such a way that basic education rather than the traditional sub-sectors of education should become the main focus of the meeting and of its formal report. Even those countries which felt that secondary education was crucially important had to accept the following redefinition of post-primary education: 'Universal access to, and completion of, primary education (or whatever higher level of education is considered as "basic") by the year 2000' (WCEFA, 1990, Framework for Action, paragraph 8.2).

By the time the World Conference finally convened, it was by no means the case that a final agreed text had been reached. Negotiation went on right up through the last night before the plenary presentation of the Declaration and the Framework for Action. An example of these last minute changes was the agreement of the international steering committee to include the time-bound target for providing primary education for all. Only the personal intervention by the then Executive Director of UNICEF, Jim Grant, secured the agreement that the target should be 2000. It is of course important to underline that it was only the primary schooling aspect of basic education that was attached to the target of 2000.[5]

Although the final text conveyed a rather comprehensive scope for basic education, two of the principal multilateral sponsoring agencies, UNICEF and the World Bank, had already made it plain in public sessions at the Conference that they would actually be focusing their funding on primary schooling (*NORRAG NEWS* 8, 1990b, pp. 16–17). Indeed, UNICEF had prepared for the World Conference an early draft of a major monograph they had commissioned on *Schooling All the Children* (Colclough & Lewin, 1993) which was exclusively about primary education; and the World Bank made available in Jomtien the near-to-final draft of its 1990 policy paper on primary education (World Bank, 1990). So the two most influential multilateral agencies in this World Conference initiative had made clear that primary schooling would be a more accessible target than the other dimensions of basic education. This is a topic that points to an important strategic rift within at least three of the key sponsors—that primary schooling, for UNICEF and the World Bank, was politically and numerically a much more attractive target than the worlds of early childhood, adult literacy, and adult and youth skills. UNESCO, by contrast, had always had a wider remit on education, including particularly a strong commitment to adult literacy and adult education. This distinction between the narrower primary education agenda and the more inclusive approach to basic education is something that would recur in the 1990s, as we shall see.

As to the character of the final agreed text, it should again be emphasized, in the light of the subsequent narrowing of the global education agenda, that the Jomtien Declaration and Framework were not as prescriptive as is sometimes thought. Although UNICEF had secured agreement on a time-bound target for primary schooling by 2000, the final version of the Framework was much more provisional: 'Countries may wish to set their own targets for the 1990s in terms of the following proposed dimensions…' (WCEFA, 1990, Framework for Action, paragraph 8).[6] There then followed the six suggested dimensions (not targets or goals):

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> (1) expansion of early childhood care and development activities, including family and community interventions, especially for poor, disadvantaged and disabled children;
>
> (2) universal access to, and completion of, primary (or whatever higher level of education is considered as 'basic') by the year 2000;
>
> (3) improvement of learning achievement such that an agreed percentage of an age cohort (e.g., 80% per cent of 14-year-olds) attains or surpasses a defined level of necessary learning achievement;
>
> (4) reduction of the adult illiteracy rate (the appropriate age-group to be determined in each country) to, say, one half its 1990 level by the year 2000, with sufficient emphasis on female literacy to significantly reduce the current disparity between male and female illiteracy rates;
>
> (5) expansion of provision of basic education and training in other essential skills required by youth and adults, with programme effectiveness assessed in terms of behavioural change and impact on health, employment and productivity;
>
> (6) increased acquisition by individuals and families of the knowledge, skills and values required for better living and sound and sustainable development, made available through all education channels including the mass media, other forms of modern and traditional communication, and social action, with effectiveness assessed in terms of behavioural change. (WCEFA, 1990, Framework for Action, paragraph 8)

If we were to summarize the role of southern governments, researchers and NGOs in affecting substantially the content of the Jomtien Declaration and Framework for Action, it was minor, if not minimal. Of course, key personnel were included in the international steering group, there were regional meetings held in southern capitals to discuss particular drafts, and there were NGO partners and government representatives in most of the official national delegations. But the core drafting personnel were drawn from the multilateral agencies. What national governments actually thought about the excision from the global education agenda of secondary, technical and vocational education and training, and higher education is not recorded in the Declaration or the Framework. The mere fact of its being a World Conference at which 155 national delegations were present is judged to be sufficient to suggest that the Jomtien agenda was widely shared across the world—which it almost certainly was not.

The Development Assistance Committee of the OECD shapes the twenty-first century

By 1996, when a slightly late mid-term conference was held in Amman en route to the target date of 2000, it was already clear that there was going to be serious slippage on the achievement of EFA by 2000 (*NORRAG NEWS* 19, 1996). But a much more significant event for determining the global education agenda was held under the aegis of the Development Assistance Committee (DAC) of the OECD in that same year—the publication of *Shaping the 21st Century: The Contribution of Development Cooperation* (OECD/DAC, 1996). Its purpose was to synthesize the lessons learned from the first seven World Conferences. Much more needs to be known about this process, what

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was lost and gained in selective translation into the final document and its six International Development Targets (IDTs). But it does appear that the Japanese, then becoming in quantitative terms the lead bilateral donor, had played an important initiating role, but that another multilateral agency, the UNDP, had provided some of the key input that became *Shaping the 21st Century*.[7]

The IDTs reinforced the narrowing of the education agenda that had already become evident in the preferences of the World Bank and UNICEF at Jomtien. The new targets focus on just two aspects of education: universal primary education by 2015 and progress towards gender equality and the empowerment of women by the elimination of gender disparity in primary and secondary education by 2005. Realistically, the universal primary education (UPE) target was reset 15 years later than the Jomtien goal of 2000 but, illogically, the goal for the elimination of gender disparities in education was set for 2005.[8] The wider set of four other economic, social and environmental targets were all time-bound for the identical date, 2015.

It is worth noting that the two International Development Targets which relate to education contain, in the one case, an emphasis on gender disparity that was not so evident in Jomtien, but was reinforced by the Cairo (1994) and Beijing (1995) Conferences; but they also, in the other case, mark a narrower version of the primary education target than at the World Conference at Jomtien. There, the text had emphasized both the access to and the completion of basic education, as well as measurable learning achievement. Now, the IDT simply talked of 'universal primary education in all countries by 2015' (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 9). It is intriguing that the DAC goal of primary education did take such a narrow perspective on education, when it justified it in the following terms: 'The attainment of basic literacy and numeracy skills has been identified repeatedly as the most significant factor in reducing poverty and increasing participation by individuals in the economic, political and cultural life of their societies' (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 9).[9]

But as so often happens in social sector policy-making, the more measurable quantitative goals took precedence over the other issues that the Report also strongly emphasized. Thus, there was recognition in the Report that there were a whole series of '*qualitative factors*' that were actually 'essential to the attainment of these measurable goals' (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 2, emphasis in the original). These included 'capacity development for effective, democratic and accountable governance, the protection of human rights and respect for the rule of law'. Like the Jomtien Framework, the text actually stressed the need for a highly context-dependent approach which gives a very different feel from the one-size-fits-all shape of the six IDTs: '… these goals must be pursued country by country through individual approaches that reflect local conditions and locally-owned development strategies' (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 2).

So, just as the Jomtien targets were generalized in subsequent reporting without the crucial qualification which preceded them—'Countries may wish to set their own targets for the 1990s in terms of the following proposed dimensions …' (WCEFA, 1990, Framework for Action, paragraph 8)—similarly these six more quantifiable DAC targets became the well-known dimensions of the DAC Report. Governance, human rights, the rule of law, not to mention 'significantly increased rates of per

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capita economic growth' (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 10) were simply sidelined, despite their being essential to the achievement of the IDTs. A parallel process would be seen just four years later when the Millennium Development Goals would be carved out of the much more demanding and comprehensive Millennium Declaration. Again, the more measurable goals would take precedence over other equally important dimensions of the Declaration.

From reading the complete text of the DAC Report, which is full of the rhetoric of national self-reliance and country ownership, it would be possible to conclude that it was not concerned with a narrow IDT agenda of 6 global goals for all developing countries, but rather with countries setting their own targets and strategies:

> As a basic principle, locally-owned country development strategies and targets should emerge from an open and collaborative dialogue by local authorities with civil society and with external partners, about their shared objectives and their respective contributions to the common enterprise. (OECD/DAC, 1996, p. 14)

Despite the pervasive rhetoric in the Report about developing countries driving the action, and about external aid only being a complement to country action, it is clearly from this particular Report that the new global agenda emerges. As the title of the Report more honestly implies, it was in fact the donors who were 'shaping the twenty-first century'. Indeed, unlike the World Conferences whose conclusions the DAC Report sought to synthesize, the developing countries were not even present at the Thirty-Fourth High Level Meeting of the Development Assistance Committee of 6–7 May 1996 which formally adopted *Shaping the 21st Century* on their behalf. The world's IDTs were thus agreed in Paris.

One of the key mechanisms in all human discourse is the summarizing and synthesizing which is judged to be necessary for capturing the essence of a book, a conference or a report. Executive Summaries and Policy Briefs remove the qualifications and they generalize across an often much more complex reality. Hence, while policy-makers don't actually read the DAC Report of 1996, they nevertheless understand that it is the source of the six key International Development Targets. Jomtien gets summarized as being about reaching UPE by 2000, and there are many other examples of what gets 'lost in translation'.[10]

In the case of the International Development Targets, which multilateral and bilateral agencies seized upon for their own purposes, it would be intriguing to see whether they retained the caveats and qualifications that were there in the original. For example, the Japanese International Cooperation Agency's Institute for International Cooperation published three volumes on the Development Targets; and for the new Labour Government in the UK, which came to power in 1997 within a year of the DAC Report, the IDTs provided a perfect global framework for a new White Paper on International Development. However, as can be seen from the box summarizing the IDTs (see Figure 1), the Department for International Development (DFID, the UK's renamed bilateral development agency), was careful to include the crucial caveat about the qualitative dimensions of development that were critical to the achievement of the quantitative targets (see also DFID, 2000):

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INTERNATIONAL DEVELOPMENT TARGETS

The international development targets are designed to provide milestones against which progress towards the goal of poverty elimination can be measured.

Economic Well-being
- a reduction by one-half in the proportion of people living in extreme poverty by 2015.

Human Development
- universal primary education in all countries by 2015
- demonstrated progress towards gender equality and the empowerment of women by eliminating gender disparity in primary and secondary education by 2005
- a reduction by two-thirds in the mortality rates for infants and children under age 5 and a reduction by three-fourths in maternal mortality, all by 2015
- access through the primary health-care system to reproductive health services for all individuals of appropriate ages as soon as possible and no later than the year 2015

Environmental Sustainability and Regeneration
- the implementation of national strategies for sustainable development in all countries by 2005, so as to ensure that current trends in the loss of environmental resources are effectively reversed at both global and national levels by 2015

While not amenable to quantification, there is a range of qualitative elements of development that are essential to the attainment of the quantitative targets. These include democratic accountability, the protection of human rights and the rule of law.

Figure 1. UK international development targets (DFID, 1997, p. 21, emphasis in the original)

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World Forum on Education for All: the six Dakar targets

By the time the development community reconvened 10 years after Jomtien in Dakar on 26–28 April 2000, it was already clear that it had been too optimistic in hoping to achieve universal primary education by 2000. What is important for our purposes here is that Dakar provided an opportunity for UNESCO in particular to reinforce the wider understanding of basic education which had been present in Jomtien but

which the DAC Report had shrunk to just two items. Thus the Collective Commitment at Dakar covered most of the original Jomtien dimensions, but also altered the expression of these. For instance, the quality of education was emphasized more powerfully than in Jomtien, and, arguably, the substitution of 'life skills' for 'essential skills required by youth and adults' weakened the importance of skills development (UNESCO, 2000, p. 16).

What is worth noting in this reassertion of UNESCO's role in framing the international education agenda is that there is actually no mention of the fact that the Dakar Conference had been obliged to adopt the new timeline of the DAC Report, (there is no mention of the Report at all); nor was there acknowledgement that it had also included in its 6 targets (see Figure 2) a very slightly reworked version of the second education IDT about gender disparities in education. [11]

As to whether this reaffirmed, if revised, Jomtien agenda reflected a genuinely global consensus of national policy-makers, this might also be in doubt. Certainly of the main plenary speeches only one was from a representative of the developing countries (the President of the host nation, Senegal). All the other plenary speakers were either from the original four sponsoring multilateral agencies, joined by the United Nations Programme on HIV/AIDS and the United Nations Population Fund, or they represented key bilaterals, the United Kingdom, the Netherlands, Canada, and the United States. Only one was from a non-governmental organization. James Wolfensohn, then President of the World Bank, was open enough to admit that 'The Bank,

The six Dakar targets

- expanding and improving comprehensive early childhood care and education, especially for the most vulnerable and disadvantaged children;
- ensuring that by 2015 all children, particularly girls, children in difficult circumstances and those belonging to ethnic minorities, have access to and complete free and compulsory primary education of good quality;
- ensuring that learning needs of all young people and adults are met through equitable access to appropriate learning and life skills programmes;
- achieving 50% improvement in levels of adult literacy by 2015, especially for women, and equitable access to basic and continuing education for all adults;
- eliminating gender disparities in primary and secondary education by 2005, and achieving gender equality in education by 2015, with a focus on ensuring girls' full and equal access to and achievement in basic education of good quality;
- improving all aspects of the quality of education and ensuring excellence of all so that recognised and measurable learning outcomes are achieved by all, especially in literacy, numeracy and essential life skills.

Figure 2. The six Dakar targets (UNESCO, 2000)

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together with our UN agency partners, and bilateral development sponsors, have led the EFA process over the past 10 years' and in stressing that 'country ownership and leadership is [sic] the key to moving forward' went on to say that evidence of these was clear in the adoption of the Comprehensive Development Framework (CDF), and the Poverty Reduction Strategy Papers (PRSPs) (Wolfensohn, 2000, p. 2). In fact, many countries might see the spread of these modalities more as evidence of new conditionalities than as evidence of country ownership.

Millennium Development Goals (2000): a new external vision of development?

Just five months after Dakar, on 6–8 September 2000, world leaders attended a further global summit, this time to debate and affirm the Millennium Declaration. In New York there were far more heads of state than at Jomtien or Dakar, and the Millennium Declaration was far more ambitious in its coverage than the declarations at these earlier education summits. It is often said that this Summit approved the Millennium Development Goals. The truth is, rather, that the Summit merely approved the Millennium Declaration, which contained a very much wider set of resolutions than the eight Millennium Goals.[12] The latter were finally agreed within the UN bureaucracy quite some time after the heads of state had departed New York. By the time they were agreed, they were much narrower than the scope of the Millennium Declaration, and much more complex, in the sense that there were now 8 Goals, 18 associated Targets, and no less than 48 indicators. To be sure, most of the language of the 8 Goals had been there in the Declaration but, like the 6 IDTs of the DAC Report four years earlier, the 8 MDGs were a selection out of the Declaration. Like the DAC Targets, the MDGs left on the sideline many essential conditions, and not least those concerned with the requirement of good governance at the level of each country, as well as good governance at the international level and transparency in the international trading system (UN General Assembly, 2000).

When all was said and done the MDGs were, despite all the discussions around the Millennium Declaration, virtually the same as the IDTs. One of the 6 IDTs had been divided into two, reproductive health services had been removed, and HIV/AIDS had been added, along with a catch-all Goal 8, 'Develop a Global Partnership for Development'. Intriguingly, the 7 Goals that involved actions in the south all had time-lines, while the resolutions and targets relating to the north did not.[13]

What had happened to the Six Dakar Targets of just 5 months earlier? In the best tradition of rapidly changing agency priorities, these had been shrunk back again to the two education IDTs of 1996. The achievement of free and compulsory primary education of good quality of the Dakar text was back to merely achieving universal primary education. Gender equality and the empowerment of women were retained from the DAC Report, including the retention of the impossible and illogical 2005 date. As with the DAC target, the goal of progress towards 'gender equality and the empowerment of women' was to be secured simply by eliminating gender disparity in primary and secondary education by 2005.[14] All the other 4 Dakar Targets were left aside.

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It is difficult to be sure what these arcane processes say about the status of different multilateral organizations, but it is hard to avoid concluding that UNESCO was not able to secure in the negotiations either the range of its concerns with basic education or the specific conditions, such as education of good quality, when it came to translating these into global targets. These requirements merely got lost in translation.

A more general concern with the whole Millennium Process towards the MDGs is that they, along with their targets and indicators, are predominantly a set of social targets. They are removed from the productive capacities and growth requirements needed to secure and sustain them, as the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development would argue (Gore, 2005). Indeed, this would also be the view of Japan:

> The primary goal of the MDGs is 'the eradication of extreme poverty and hunger.' Japan believes that increasing the income of the people of developing countries, especially the poor, through economic growth is crucial for achieving this foremost objective of the MDGs. (Japan, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2005)

The view that the world's global development agenda can seriously be proposed without a detailed calculation of how it can be sustained financially has not been given sufficient analytical attention. Of course since 2005, there have been the Millennium Project Report of Sachs (UN, 2005) and the Commission for Africa (2005) to argue that the Goals are indeed achievable, but only through a hugely ambitious investment programme in infrastructure, rural and urban development, foreign direct investment, increased levels of foreign aid and much else. This has begun to make for a more realistic approach to the Goals in some quarters. Even earlier, Michael Clemens, through examining 'international education goals in historical perspective', had affirmed that the short time horizons associated with the constant setting and resetting of goals were counterproductive. They take insufficient account of the factors that have really secured and sustained school enrolment over time:

> Raising school enrolment, like economic development in general, takes a long time. This is partly because, as a mountain of empirical evidence now shows, economic conditions and slowly-changing parental education levels determine children's school enrolment to a greater degree than education policy interventions. (Clemens, 2004, p. 1)

Building a monitoring superstructure on top of the MDGs and the Dakar targets

Once the MDGs had been agreed after the Summit of 2000, they were used to justify a whole process of tracking and assessing the progress of the world's developing countries against them. The MDGs led directly to the Millennium Project, the Millennium Campaign, the Millennium Project Report, and all its supporting documentation. A whole section of the aid industry, with expert groups, was organized around the assessment of the MDGs. The MDGs can be tracked globally, at the regional level, and at the level of each country. The UNDP's country offices produce regular joint MDG reports with individual countries. There are now UNDP MDG websites around the world from Bolivia to Bhutan and from Somalia to South

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Africa. The MDG framework provides a useful framework for other agencies to use to judge their country strategies; thus Japan has employed it to present its ODA activity (Japan, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2005), and DFID in its country profiles uses a special heading about the MDGs to judge the MDG progress of each of the many countries in which it works.

If UNDP is the main multilateral agency monitoring the MDG process across the world, but funded by eleven bilateral agencies and UNESCO, with its own separate funding, Editorial Board and Executive Director. The reports thus far have been of very high quality and influential, though perhaps more with the donor community than in the south (see, for example, UNESCO, 2006).

Both these monitoring activities take their respective targets and goals as legitimate global agreements, and proceed to assess whether the world is on track to meet them. It is a vital assumption for their credibility to accept that the targets and goals are actually owned in the very countries which are tracked, assessed, and monitored. But what if the countries on the receiving end of these assessments regard their participation in these exercises more as passive acceptance of activities being carried out by the UNDP and by the team in UNESCO? Perhaps there has been insufficient attention to the processes whereby these different frameworks of the world's declared global agenda are actually embedded in the south, and are owned by the south.

It may well be the case that this particular architecture of international development needs much more detailed analysis in the developing world. What evidence may there be that the very narrowness of the education goals and targets has constrained external aid to secondary, technical and higher education, and especially in the most aid-dependent countries? And even in those countries (such as China, South Africa and India) that are not aid-dependent, do the MDGs and the Dakar Targets really fit in with their established planning processes? Probably not (King, 2006; see also King & Rose, 2005).

Planners in the various fields and sectoral ministries covered by the MDGs—Health, Education, Water, Environment and Housing—are unlikely to be able politically to focus on just the minimalist targets of the MDGs. And in the sphere of education, no Ministers could expect to survive very long if their agendas were to be circumscribed by the two Education MDGs/IDTs, or even by the six aspects of basic education from Dakar. The value of the analysis by Sachs (UN, 2005) and by the Commission for Africa (2005) is that they demonstrated very persuasively that the MDGs and education targets could not be reached by simply focusing on them. Rather they had to be reconceptualized and made just one part of much more holistic sectoral and inter-sectoral development projects.

Notes

1. For the regional conferences and their time-lines, see: http://www.unesco.org/education/educprog/50y/brochure/unintwo/74.htm.
2. Communication with Kazuo Takahashi, former director of the Foundation for Advanced Studies in International Development (FASID), Tokyo.

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3. An early indication of the direction of the Conference was evident in UNICEF-UNESCO-World Bank (September 1988) 'Moving towards basic education for all' (internal paper).
4. Latin American delegates and the regional consultation in Latin America insisted that higher education be included.
5. UNICEF's targeting of education could well have happened before their very successful targeting of basic health initiatives in the 1980s, if UNESCO had been more responsive (Richard Jolly to Kenneth King, 18 January 2006).
6. Wadi Haddad, the Executive Secretary of the Jomtien Conference, has since said 'the notion of the individual nation and its decisions was changed into a single global target … for 2000; this was a global mistake and so was the later target of 2015' (personal communication, Washington 15 June 2004).
7. According to Richard Jolly (former adviser to the Administrator of UNDP between 1996 and 2000, and previously the Deputy Executive Director of UNICEF) Japan and the UNDP were involved in the development of the IDTs as follows: 'My understanding is that the Japanese pressed DAC to prepare a paper with a vision for the 21st century. DAC did this and it was presented to DAC in 1995—but was both vague and weak and the Japanese (and others?) were far from content. At that point, the Japanese turned informally to the Human Development Report Office, and in particular to Sakiko Fukuda Parr and Selim Jahan. Sakiko, and Selim prepared a paper with quantitative goals and sent it via the Japanese mission—who in turn submitted it as a revised version to DAC. This is the one which became *Shaping the 21st Century: the Contribution of Development Cooperation*, issued by DAC in May 1996' (Jolly to King, 18 January 2006).
8. How gender disparity in the basic cycle of education could be realistically dealt with 10 years before universal primary education remains a mystery.
9. It may be surmised that the UNDP or DAC drafting committee could have been influenced by the World Bank's famous research which claimed that a few years of primary education made a difference to agricultural productivity as well as to improved health and decreased fertility (see King & Palmer, 2006). There was little parallel research that had been carried out on the same assumptions about the impact of adult literacy and essential skills.
10. One of the most famous examples of what gets lost in translation is the finding that 'four years of education makes a difference to farmer productivity'. This turns out, on closer inspection, to be a misrepresentation of the original World Bank research (see King & Palmer, 2006).
11. For a detailed critique of the World Education Forum, see *NORRAG NEWS* 26.
12. Typical of this misreading is the introduction by the UN team to the 2004 MDG Report on China: 'At the September 2000 United Nations Summit, 149 Heads of State and Government from 189 member countries adopted the Millennium Declaration, a document outlining a universal set of development goals' (UNDP, 2004, p.1).
13. Under Goal 8, these non time-bound targets included tariff and quota-free access for least developed countries' exports; access to increased aid; affordable drugs; decent and productive work; debt relief and much else.
14. The only difference between the DAC IDT and the MDG was that the latter was explained unhelpfully in its Target as follows: Eliminate gender disparity in primary and secondary education, preferably by 2005, and in all levels of education no later than 2015': http://millenniumindicators.un.org/unsd/mdg/Host.aspx?Content=Indicator. By contrast, the text of the Millennium Declaration had actually got rid of the anomaly of 2005.

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